



Australian Government
Department of Employment
and Workplace Relations

Personnel Security Policy

Department of Employment and Workplace
Relations



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Document History

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1.0	9/03/2024	Blake Parsons	Rewrite of Personnel Security Policy due to changes to the PSPF 2025 release.	Draft	Scott Kemmis - ASA
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Contents

Document Particulars	3
Document History	3
Scope.....	5
Purpose of personnel security.....	5
Personnel Security Risks	5
Mitigating personnel security risk	6
Pre-employment screening	6
Security clearances	7
Clearance holders from other agencies	8
Ongoing suitability and security clearance maintenance	8
Security awareness and training	8
Separation process	9
Briefings.....	9
Security incidents	10
Relevant tip sheets.....	10

Scope

This Personnel Security Policy and Procedures applies to all persons employed by the Department of Employment and Workplace Relations (DEWR). This also applies to consultants, contractors, sub-contractors and contracted service providers and any other user of the department's systems of premises. For the purposes of this document all staff, consultants, contractors, sub-contractors and contracted service providers will be referred to as 'person' or 'worker'.

This Policy aligns with the mandated requirements of the Protective Security Policy Framework's (PSPF) Personnel security policies covering Policy 12: Eligibility and suitability of personnel, Policy 13: Ongoing assessment of personnel and Policy 14: Separating personnel.

Purpose of personnel security

Personnel security is used for the purpose of screening and vetting personnel and contractors to assess their eligibility and suitability to work with and for the Australian Government. It is about determining and managing the department's security risks as they relate to the ongoing suitability of personnel to access Australian Government resources and managing personnel separation while maintaining an appropriate standard of integrity and honesty.

Personnel Security Risks

Through effective personnel security processes the department is able to mitigate the threat posed by "trusted insiders".

The Australian Government defines the threat of a trusted insider as:

'The threat posed by unauthorised access, use or disclosure of privileged information, techniques, technology, assets or premises by an individual with legitimate or indirect access, which may cause harm.'

There are two broad categories of trusted insiders who pose a threat:

- the **unintentional insider** - trusted employees or contractors who inadvertently expose, or make vulnerable to loss or exploitation, privileged information, techniques, technology, assets or premises. Inadvertent actions include poor security practices, such as leaving IT systems unattended and failure to secure sensitive documents, and unwitting unauthorised disclosure to a third party.
- the **malicious insider** - trusted employees and contractors who deliberately and wilfully breach their duty to maintain the security of privileged information, techniques, technology, assets or premises. There are two types of malicious insiders:
 - self-motivated insiders are individuals whose actions are undertaken of their own volition, and not initiated as the result of any connection to, or direction by, a third party
 - recruited insiders are individuals co-opted by a third party to specifically exploit their potential, current or former privileged access. This includes cultivated and recruited foreign intelligence, or their entities with malicious intent.

Security risk exposures arising from insider threat can include:

- violence to other departmental people, clients or members of the public
- the unauthorised disclosure or altering of Australian Government information
- physical or electronic sabotage
- facilitation of third-party access
- financial or process corruption
- fraud or theft.

Mitigating personnel security risk

To ensure all personnel are aware of their responsibilities and agree that they will safeguard the department's resources against loss, misuse or compromise, the department obtains a signed non-disclosure agreement and a fraud and conflict of interest declaration. In addition, the department will:

- conduct relevant checks before personnel gain access to resources to confirm their eligibility to do so
- manage the ongoing suitability of a person to access resources throughout their engagement
- remind staff of their ongoing obligation to protect the resources to which they have had access following the cessation of their engagement with the department.

Pre-employment screening

Pre-employment screening conducted during the on-boarding process provides a level of assurance on the eligibility and suitability of personnel to access the department's official information and resources and is to be completed prior to the person commencing with the department and prior to granting a person access to the department's official information and resources.

Pre-employment screening includes:

- verifying the person's identity through authenticating their Australian issued primary identification documents using the Document Verification Service
 - where personal documents are not in English it will be necessary to obtain a translation from a National Accreditation Authority for Translators and Interpreters (NAATI) accredited provider
- confirming the person's citizenship (or eligibility to work in Australia)
- the applicant completing a National Police Check
 - In the event that a Disclosable Court Outcome (DCO) is notified to the department, the department will apply the outcomes against its Disclosable Court Outcomes decision questionnaire to fairly and consistently assess the approval of staff and contractors' commencement with the department.
- conducting other assurance checks as necessary.

For further details on the pre-employment screening process refer to the [Security and On-boarding tip sheet](#).

Security clearances

Consistent with the requirements of the PSPF, given the department has in place a Protected desktop environment, all staff are required to obtain and maintain at least a Baseline level security clearance. If access to material above **PROTECTED** is required, a higher-level clearance will be sought. Also, the department may use higher level security clearances where there is a need for additional assurance and integrity arising from the requirements of a position. Mandatory minimum clearance levels for all positions in the department are listed in Attachment A.

Security clearances can only be obtained if they are sponsored by an Australian government agency. Where an individual holds, or has previously held, a security clearance sponsored by another government body, the department may assume sponsorship, thus activating the security clearance as long as it has not expired.

New staff joining the department, with a cleared National Police Check, may be permitted to join the department and access the IT environment on a temporary basis (a maximum of three months in a 12 month period) prior to them obtaining a Baseline level security clearance. In the event that a clearance is not granted, the offer of employment may be withdrawn.

As is mandated in the PSPF, the department uses the Australian Government Security Vetting Agency (AGSVA) to conduct the security clearances it requires. AGSVA is the central vetting agency for the Australian Government and conducts security clearance assessments for federal, state and territory government bodies.

In assessing a person's suitability for a clearance, AGSVA will make a judgement against the character traits of maturity, trustworthiness, honesty, resilience, tolerance and loyalty. Should a clearance request be declined by AGSVA, it can be appealed. The Protective Security Team can advise about the process.

Only Australian citizens with a checkable background can obtain a security clearance. The relevant checking period is 5 years for a Baseline clearance and 10 years for a Negative Vetting 1 and Negative Vetting 2 clearance.

In exceptional circumstances, the department's Accountable Authority may waive the citizenship or checkable background requirement for a person after completing a risk assessment. Please contact the Agency Security Advisor for further details. Please note, AGSVA may still decline the clearance even if a waiver is in place.

Once granted, security clearances are subject to periodic review. The revalidation process is similar to the initial clearance process and includes updated personal particulars, background check covering the period since previous clearance assessment, digital footprint checks, national police check and financial history check (if applicable). Table 1 outlines the revalidation periods, and the highest level of the material that is accessible at each of the four clearance levels.

Table 1: Security Clearances

Security Clearance Level	Baseline	Negative Vetting 1	Negative Vetting 2	TOP SECRET-Privileged Access (Or Positive Vetting)
Period of validation	15 years	10 years	7 years	7 years ²
Highest permitted access	PROTECTED	SECRET	TOP SECRET¹	TOP SECRET IT Systems³

¹ In hardcopy only² Requires an annual security appraisal³ Requires additional briefings

Clearance holders from other agencies

When an officer from another Commonwealth agency requires access to departmental resources, a Certificate of Suitability will need to be completed by the officer and their Agency Security Advisor, and certified by the department's Protective Security Team.

Ongoing suitability and security clearance maintenance

Maintaining awareness of changes to a person's personal circumstances and workplace behaviours is essential to ensure their ongoing suitability to access the department's information and resources.

Managers are required to monitor the behaviours of their people and report any concerns about suitability for access to security classified resources to the Protective Security Team and/or the Agency Security Advisor (ASA). The ASA may share information about security concerns with AGSVA or other government agencies as mandated by the PSPF.

Formally each year, the department conducts an Annual Security Health Checks for each employee. The Annual Security Health Check is a simple process to confirm staff have complied with their security clearance obligations including:

- reporting all relevant changes in personal circumstances to ASGVA via its myClearance portal
- reporting all security incidents
- confirming they have updated their personal particulars with the department and complied with the department's conflict of interest policy
- confirming they have reported any suspicious, ongoing, unusual or persistent contacts
- undertaking annual security training.

Security awareness and training

Security Awareness Training is a mandatory requirement for those who perform work for the department. The department provides all personnel, including contractors, with security awareness training at engagement and annually thereafter.

Specific and targeted awareness sessions can also be organised for business areas by contacting the Protective Security Team. Staff in high-risk positions will be provided with supplementary training commensurate with the risk of their positions.

Failure to complete or attend security awareness training will be treated as a breach of the protective security policy and personnel may be subject to misconduct and/or performance action.

Separation process

If staff are leaving the department permanently or temporarily for a period of more than three months (this is inclusive of all forms of extended leave), they are required to complete an Exit Notification/Extended Leave form.

The mandatory Exit Notification Form ensures the department is able to:

- meet its security obligations specified in the Protective Security Policy Framework
- reclaim licences and costs associated with user licences
- ensure access to department systems is limited to only appropriate users
- maintain up-to-date contact details
- track and recover the allocation of IT assets and resources owned by the department.

The form is also used to verify data in the Exit Checklist.

For more information or if you have any questions, you can visit the Leaving the Department page, speak with your manager or contact ServiceDesk@dewr.gov.au who will be able to assist you lodge the forms.

Leaving employment (either permanent or temporary) with the department does not negate the requirement for personnel to continue to comply with security requirements as legislative and procedural arrangements relating to the non-disclosure of information still apply.

In accordance with [PSPF personnel security policy](#), the department will debrief all separating personnel who have had access to sensitive or security classified information to advise them of their continuing obligations under relevant legislation (such as the *Criminal Code Act 1995*) and obtain the person's acknowledgement of their ongoing non-disclosure obligations.

Should a person leave the department without the completion of the separation process, a risk assessment will need to be undertaken by their manager to identify any security implications.

The department will advise AGSVA of the staff member's separation and if there are any security issues associated with their departure. This action will remove departmental sponsorship of their clearance. Security clearances may be reactivated by the receiving agency if it is within the revalidation period.

The department will also provide any relevant security information about an officer (including advice on pre-employment checks) should they be transferring to another Commonwealth entity.

For more information refer to the [Security, Promotions and Off-boarding tip sheet](#).

Briefings

Holders of Negative Vetting 1, Negative Vetting 2 and TOP SECRET-Privileged Access (or Positive Vetting) may be able to access codeword material should they obtain the relevant briefing from the department

or the codeword owner. There must be a clear business requirement to obtain a briefing and staff **must** already hold a clearance at the appropriate level. Temporary access is not permitted.

Staff who have been briefed into the CHARLIE, DELTA or any other compartment should renew their briefings every 5 years. Staff must be de-briefed from a compartment when they leave the department or are no longer working in a role that requires them to maintain the briefing. Minimum clearance levels are shown below in Table 2.

Table 2: Minimum security clearance requirements for briefings

	CHARLIE	DELTA
Negative Vetting 1	For irregular access	Access not permitted
Negative Vetting 2	For irregular access	Access permitted
TOP SECRET-Privileged Access (or Positive Vetting)	For ongoing access	Access permitted

For further details on briefings refer to the [Protecting Codeword \(CHARLIE & DELTA\) Information](#) tip sheet.

Security incidents

Any loss, compromise or incident regarding official information, including the loss and damage to ICT equipment must be reported in an online [Security Incident Report form](#) at the earliest opportunity.

For incidents that could potentially have a significant impact on the department, please report these immediately to the Protective Security Team via:

- Email – Protective Security (protectivesecurity@dewr.gov.au) or
- Telephone – Ext 46696 or 6240 6969; or Mobile – 0434 538 047 (afterhours).

The immediate reporting of serious security incidents is necessary to ensure that issues arising from the incident can be contained and the incident effectively managed.

Relevant tip sheets

For further information, please refer to the following tip sheets:

- [Security and On-boarding](#)
- [Security for Managers](#)
- [Security, Promotions and Off-boarding](#)

Mandatory minimum clearance levels

Position	Minimum Security Clearance Required
Communications Intelligence Security Officer (COMSO) & Deputy COMSO	TOP SECRET-Privileged Access or Positive Vetting (ASD requirement)
Secretary	Negative Vetting 2
Senior Executive Service (SES) Band 3	Negative Vetting 2
Senior Executive Service (SES) Band 2 with an International footprint or Security function	Negative Vetting 2
Senior Executive Service (SES) Band 2	Negative Vetting 1
Protective Security staff EL2s/EL1s	Negative Vetting 2
Executive Level Officers (EL2s/EL1s) with an International footprint or Security Function	Negative Vetting 2 with supporting business case (NV1 otherwise).
General Counsel, FAS	Negative Vetting 2
Pacific Labour Operations EL2s and above	Negative Vetting 2 (with supporting business case - NV1 otherwise).
Minister-Counsellor (International Labour Organization) Geneva	Negative Vetting 2 (DFAT requirement)
Executive Officer and Executive Assistants	Baseline - (Higher level with supporting business case).
Senior Executive Service (SES) Band 1	Baseline - (NV1 with supporting business case).
Department Liaison Officer (DLO) & Cabinet Liaison Officer (CLO) to access the CABNET System (PM&C requirement)	Negative Vetting 1
DFAT SATIN HIGH and SATIN LOW	Negative Vetting 1
Data Centres staff	Negative Vetting 1
'Privileged Access' (Administrators) and their EL Managers.	Negative Vetting 1
Protective Security APS staff	Negative Vetting 1
All other staff/ contractors	Baseline

Changes in circumstances

Changes in personal circumstances to be reported to AGSVA by the clearance holder (via the myClearance portal) include:

- change of name or identity including gender
- changes in significant relationships
- changes of address or share-housing arrangements
- entering into, or ceasing, a marriage, domestic partnership or significant personal relationship
- changes in citizenship or nationality
- changes in financial circumstances, like entering into a mortgage, incurring a significant debt, significant change to household income, receiving a lump sum payment or other financial windfall
- changes in health or medical circumstances
- changes in criminal history, police involvement and association with criminal activity
- involvement or association with any group, society or organisation
- involvement with any individual that may be a security concern
- disciplinary procedures
- illicit or illegal drug use or alcohol problems
- residence in a foreign country
- relatives residing in a foreign country
- suspicious, unusual, persistent, regular or ongoing contact with foreign nationals
- changes in religious beliefs
- security incidents
- external business interests, including business activities with overseas individuals and entities
- overseas travel
- identity document replacement following a cyber-hack (such as driver's licence, passport, Medicare card).